

Melk Abbey

Towering over the River Danube in Lower Austria, Melk Abbey was commissioned by the abbot Berthold Dietmayr (1670–1739). It follows the designs of Jakob Prandtauer (c.1660–1726), and was completed in 1736 after his death by his nephew, Joseph Munggenast (1680–1741). The Benedictine abbey, church and monastery is the largest in Austria and Germany, standing as a bastion of Catholicism and exemplifying the spirited approach to the baroque taken by its country's architects. On the site of a previous 11th-century abbey, the imposing ochre-and-white stuccoed building features a grand dome topped by an exotic lantern, with a curved façade emphasized by two onion-domed bell towers. Planned around a central axis 320 metres (1,050ft) in length, the main building is flanked by outbuildings, including the huge marble abbey hall and a double-storey library. Elaborately painted ceilings, gilded decoration and sculpture feature throughout, created by Johann Michael Rottmayr (1656–1730), Paul Troger (1698–1762), Lorenzo Mattielli (1687–1748) and Peter Widerin (1684–1760).

